Recipe & Meal-Planning App Landscape: Research for a Pregnancy Recipe App

Summary

Mainstream recipe apps are good at planning, shopping and cooking, but none of the eight reviewed here treats pregnancy as a profile setting or flags pregnancy-unsafe ingredients. The pregnancy apps that do flag foods are mostly lookup tools or small new apps with few ratings, and they rarely join safety guidance with a full recipe-to-grocery workflow.

Apps reviewed: Mealime, Samsung Food, Paprika 3, Eat This Much, Plan to Eat, NYT Cooking, Tasty and Allrecipes, plus four pregnancy-specific food apps for contrast. Information comes from each app's App Store listing, official website and help center, read on the date above.

1. Mealime (Plan, shop, cook)

App Store · Google Play · Website · Help center · Pro features · Viewing nutrition

Point	Detail
How it works	Three steps: **Plan** (pick meals for the week from Mealime's own recipe set), **Shop** (an auto-built grocery list, sorted by category, with optional delivery partners), **Cook** (step-by-step, hands-free cooking mode). Recipes are designed for about 30 minutes.
Main features	Weekly meal plans, auto grocery list, hands-free cook mode, Apple Health sync, food-waste reduction by reusing ingredients across the week's recipes.
Organization / recommendation	Curated in-house library; the plan screen suggests recipes filtered by your profile.
Personalization	Onboarding asks for a diet (Classic, Flexitarian, Pescetarian, Low Carb, Paleo, Keto, Vegetarian, Vegan), allergies and disliked ingredients, servings and skill. The site claims 200+ personalization options.
Nutrition	Yes, in Pro: per-recipe nutrition and filtering by calories.
Meal plan / shopping list	Both, and they are the center of the app.

Point	Detail
Monetization	Free tier plus Mealime Pro at $2.99/month. The listing says Pro is now free for everyone and the app shuts down on October 21, 2026.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Onboarding that asks a few profile questions and then filters everything; a short, tightly connected plan → list → cook loop; 30-minute recipes suit fatigue in the first and third trimesters.
Weaknesses / gaps	No pregnancy setting, no food-safety flags, nutrition limited to the paid tier, closed recipe library (can't import your own).

2. Samsung Food (formerly Whisk)

App Store · Google Play · Website · Help center · Food+ features · Meal Planner guide · Nutrition and Health Score · Health goals

Point	Detail
How it works	Save recipes from any website (browser extension or share sheet) or scan them from photos into a **Recipe Box**; drag recipes onto a weekly **Meal Planner**; one tap turns a recipe or plan into a **Shopping List** you can share or send to online grocers; follow recipes in cooking mode. **Communities** let users share and discover recipes.
Main features	Recipe Box, drag-and-drop planner, smart shopping list, nutrition calculator with a Health Score, communities. Food+ adds tailored weekly plans, reusable plan templates, AI recipe adjustment ("make it healthier", ingredient swaps), "Use It Up" search by ingredients you have, Vision AI to scan food into a pantry list, AI cooking mode with Samsung appliance control, unlimited recipe scans.
Organization / recommendation	User's own collections plus community feeds organized around eating preferences and needs.
Personalization	Diet preferences and excluded foods from the profile; health goals with calorie needs from the Mifflin-St Jeor equation and macro targets based

Point	Detail
	on USDA and Dietary Guidelines. The help center does not describe allergy handling or pregnancy.
Nutrition	Yes, for any saved recipe, including macros, micronutrients and a Health Score, using USDA FoodData Central and brand labels.
Meal plan / shopping list	Both.
Monetization	Free core app; Food+ at $6.99/month or $59.99/year after a 7-day trial. Also supports Samsung's smart-appliance ecosystem.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Universal recipe import (users keep their favorite blogs); a Health Score is a model for a "Pregnancy Safety" badge; AI "swap an ingredient" is a natural way to fix an unsafe ingredient; documented nutrition sources build trust.
Weaknesses / gaps	Goals are general (weight, macros), with no life-stage targets; best features sit behind the paywall.

3. Paprika Recipe Manager 3

App Store · Google Play · Website · iOS help guide

Point	Detail
How it works	Paprika is a personal recipe manager. A built-in browser lets you find a recipe on any site and tap to download it; you can also type recipes or import files from older apps. Recipes go into your own categories; you plan meals on a day, week or month calendar and add ingredients to a grocery list.
Main features	Web clipping, categories and 0 to 5 star ratings, reusable menus, aisle-sorted grocery lists that merge duplicates (1 egg + 2 eggs = 3 eggs), a pantry with purchase and expiry dates, scaling and unit conversion, timers detected in steps, cloud sync, Apple Watch, offline use.
Organization / recommendation	Only the user's own library, searchable by name, source or ingredient. No recommendations.

Point	Detail
Personalization	None beyond the user's own categories and tags.
Nutrition	A free-text "Nutritional Info" field filled from the source; no calculation.
Meal plan / shopping list	Both, plus pantry.
Monetization	One-time purchase per platform ($4.99 on iPhone); no ads, no subscription. Rated 4.9 stars from 54K+ ratings.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Users love owning their recipes and a one-time price; pantry expiry dates matter more in pregnancy (leftovers and Listeria); merged, aisle-sorted lists are a quality bar to match.
Weaknesses / gaps	No discovery, no nutrition math, no health or safety guidance; the user must judge every recipe alone.

4. Eat This Much (automatic meal planner)

App Store · Google Play · Website · Calorie calculator · Nutrient glossary

Point	Detail
How it works	Goal-first rather than recipe-first. You choose a diet type, calorie target (or use the calculator), meals per day (1 to 6) and macro targets. The app generates a full day or week of meals that hits those numbers; you tap "regenerate" to swap a meal or the whole day, and the grocery list updates.
Main features	Auto-generated plans, regenerate/swap, virtual pantry the planner uses up first, grocery list with Instacart and AmazonFresh, meal tracking with streaks and a consistency calendar, Apple Health sync, budget and schedule settings.
Organization / recommendation	Algorithmic: meals are chosen to fit numeric targets, budget and pantry.
Personalization	Diets (Keto, Mediterranean, Paleo, Vegan, Vegetarian and more), blocked foods, calorie and macro targets, budget, cooking time.

Point	Detail
Nutrition	Yes, central: daily calories and macros against targets.
Meal plan / shopping list	Both; Premium auto-generates the week and emails the list.
Monetization	Free single-day planner; Premium from $8.99/month or about $48 to $60/year; a separate Pro tier for dietitians and trainers. Rated 4.7 stars from 22K ratings.
Useful for a pregnancy app	"Hit my targets for me" planning maps directly to pregnancy needs (extra calories in later trimesters, protein, folate, iron); regenerate keeps choice simple; a professional tier hints at a channel through dietitians and OB clinics.
Weaknesses / gaps	Built around weight loss and macros; no micronutrient targets for pregnancy; no safety rules (it could schedule sushi or a runny-egg dish).

5. Plan to Eat

App Store · Google Play · Website · FAQ · Recipe Book help · Nutrition calculation · Nutrition on the planner

Point	Detail
How it works	Save recipes from any site or social post with the **Recipe Clipper** into a personal Recipe Book; drag them onto a **calendar planner**; an organized **shopping list** builds itself. One account covers the whole family across web and phones.
Main features	Recipe clipper, drag-and-drop calendar, auto shopping list, automatic per-serving nutrition, nutrition totals on the planner, family sharing, cook mode.
Organization / recommendation	User's own library with tags and search; no editorial recommendations.
Personalization	Through the user's own choices and tags; no diet or allergy engine.

Point	Detail
Nutrition	Yes, calculated per serving from ingredients; users can flag wrong values, which staff review every two weeks.
Meal plan / shopping list	Both.
Monetization	Subscription only, no ads: 14-day free trial, then $5.95/month or $49/year on the web ($54.99/year in the iOS app). Rated 4.8 stars from 6.1K ratings.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Shared family account (a partner can shop from the same list); visible nutrition totals per day on the planner; a "flag this value" loop to improve data quality, which you could reuse for safety flags.
Weaknesses / gaps	No health guidance or alerts; nutrition math still described as maturing; no discovery for users who don't already have recipes.

6. NYT Cooking

App Store · Google Play · Website · Recipe Box help

Point	Detail
How it works	An editorial library of 20,000+ tested recipes with new ones daily. Browse curated collections, search with filters (diet, cuisine, meal type, time), save to your **Recipe Box**, add ingredients to the **grocery list** (with Instacart ordering), then cook in **Cook Mode**.
Main features	Recipe Box, filters, grocery list, Cook Mode, private notes, videos and shows such as "Cooking 101".
Organization / recommendation	Editor-curated collections and named chefs; filters by diet, cuisine, meal and time.
Personalization	Filters only; no profile-based exclusions.
Nutrition	Not described in the app listing.
Meal plan / shopping list	Grocery list yes; no dedicated meal-planning calendar is described.

Point	Detail
Monetization	Subscription (about $5 to $7/month or $40 to $50/year; bundled in NYT All Access). Rated 4.9 stars from 547K ratings, Editors' Choice.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Trust comes from testing and expert voices; a pregnancy app can borrow that by having recipes reviewed by a registered dietitian and naming the reviewer on each recipe. Curated collections ("Iron-rich dinners", "Nausea-friendly snacks") are a proven discovery format.
Weaknesses / gaps	No health profile, no safety warnings, no planner.

7. Tasty (BuzzFeed)

App Store · Google Play · Website

Point	Detail
How it works	Video-first discovery. Browse 10,000+ recipes and collections with short videos, or search by up to three ingredients you have; save favorites to **personalized cookbooks**; cook step by step; buy ingredients through Walmart (delivery or pickup). An AI assistant ("Botatouille", built on ChatGPT) suggests recipes.
Main features	Videos, ingredient search, cookbooks, serving-size and unit switching, community photos, tips and "remixes", AI assistant, shoppable recipes.
Organization / recommendation	Collections, trending content and AI suggestions.
Personalization	Diet preference settings including allergies and restrictions.
Nutrition	Not described in the app listing.
Meal plan / shopping list	Shoppable Walmart cart; no meal-planning calendar is described.
Monetization	Free with ads; Tasty+ at $3.99/month or $34.99/year; Walmart commerce. Rated 4.9 stars from 433K ratings.
Useful for a pregnancy app	Short videos lower the effort of cooking; "cook with what I have" search helps on low-energy

Point	Detail
	days; an AI chat that can answer "Can I eat this?" is what users now expect.
Weaknesses / gaps	Recipes skew indulgent; ads and commerce don't fit a health-trust product; a general-purpose AI chatbot giving food-safety answers in pregnancy is a liability without vetted content.

8. Allrecipes

App Store · Website

Point	Detail
How it works	A large community library. Search by keyword, include or exclude ingredients, filter by diet and time; read ratings and reviews; save recipes and organize them into shareable collections; add ingredients to a shopping list; post "I Made It" photos.
Main features	Ingredient include/exclude search, reviews and ratings, collections, shopping list, 1,000+ videos, personalized feed, cook profiles.
Organization / recommendation	Community ratings and reviews plus a personalized feed.
Personalization	Search filters and a feed; no stored health profile.
Nutrition	Not described in the app listing.
Meal plan / shopping list	Shopping list yes; no planner described.
Monetization	Free, owned by a media publisher; ad-supported is typical but the listing does not state it.
Useful for a pregnancy app	"Exclude ingredient" search is a simple version of safety filtering; reviews like "I made it with pasteurized feta" show users adapting recipes themselves.
Weaknesses / gaps	App rated 2.7 stars (1.3K ratings) with reviews citing a stale feed and buggy search; user-submitted recipes vary in quality, which matters when safety is the promise.

Pregnancy-specific food apps

The pregnancy food apps that exist split into lookup tools with no recipes and small AI-driven apps with very few ratings; none has the scale or polish of the recipe apps above.

App	What it does	Recipes / planning	Price	Ratings
Pregnant Food: Eat or Avoid (Popcorp AB)	Safe / Be careful / Avoid answers for 1,300+ foods, with separate answers for raw vs cooked and fresh vs canned; guidance from food authorities in 9 countries, chosen by region; week-by-week tracker	No recipes	Free; $11.99 one-time to unlock full source guidance	Rating recently reset; mixed reviews on navigation and database scope
Pregnancy Food Safety MomEats	600+ food ratings, barcode scanner, AI menu-photo and recipe scanners that flag risky ingredients and suggest changes, AI voice assistant, food journal	AI-generated multi-day meal plans	Subscriptions from $2.99/week to $19.99/half-year	3.0 stars, 2 ratings
Pregnancy Diet & Meal Planner (Riafy)	Trimester-based recipes, morning-sickness options, key-nutrient guidance	Weekly plans and grocery lists	$11.49/month or $39.99/half-year	5.0 stars, 1 rating
Bloei: Pregnancy Nutrition	Pregnancy nutrition app	Not reviewed	Not reviewed	Listing could not be read (rate-limited)

Comparison

Every app has a shopping list, most have a planner and nutrition, and none has pregnancy safety checks.

App	Model	Recipe source	Diet / allergy profile	Health goals	Nutrition	Meal planner	Shopping list	Import any recipe	Pregnancy safety flags	Paid tier (US)
Mealime	Planner	In-house	Yes	No	Pro	Yes	Yes	No	No	$2.99/mo (closing)
Samsung Food	Planner + organizer	User + community	Yes	Calories, macros	Yes + Health Score	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	$6.99/mo, $59.99/yr
Paprika 3	Organizer	User	No	No	Manual field	Yes	Yes + pantry	Yes	No	$4.99 one-time
Eat This Much	Auto-planner	In-house database	Yes	Calories, macros	Yes	Yes (auto)	Yes + pantry	No	No	$8.99/mo
Plan to Eat	Organizer + planner	User	No	No	Calculated	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	$5.95/mo, $49/yr
NYT Cooking	Content	Editorial	Filters only	No	Not stated	No	Yes	No	No	~$5 to $7/mo
Tasty	Content + commerce	Editorial + community	Yes	No	Not stated	No	Walmart cart	No	No	$3.99/mo + ads
Allrecipes	Content + community	User-submitted	Filters only	No	Not stated	No	Yes	No	No	Free

Common and unique features

Common to nearly all (table stakes your app must have):

- Save recipes into a personal box or collections
- Search with filters for diet, meal type and cooking time
- One-tap shopping list, merged and sorted by aisle
- A weekly drag-and-drop planner (in the utility apps)
- Step-by-step cook mode with timers
- Serving scaling and unit conversion
- Free tier with a paid upgrade around $3 to $9 a month, or $35 to $60 a year

Unique or uncommon (worth borrowing):

Feature	App	Why it matters for pregnancy
Import from any website or photo	Samsung Food, Paprika, Plan to Eat	Users keep their favorite sources; your app checks them for safety
Auto-generate a week to hit nutrient targets, with "regenerate"	Eat This Much	Swap calorie/macro targets for trimester nutrient targets
Health Score on every recipe	Samsung Food	Model for a clear safety and nutrition badge
AI "make it healthier" ingredient swaps	Samsung Food	Turn "avoid" ingredients into safe swaps (pasteurized cheese, cooked salmon)
Pantry with expiry dates; "use it up"	Paprika, Eat This Much, Samsung Food	Leftover and storage timing matters for Listeria risk
Shared family account	Plan to Eat	Partner can plan and shop
Preparation-specific answers (raw vs cooked) and regional guidance	Pregnant Food: Eat or Avoid	Safety depends on how food is prepared and where you live
Menu and barcode scanning	MomEats	"Can I eat this?" in restaurants and stores
Editorial trust and named experts	NYT Cooking	Dietitian-reviewed recipes build credibility
One-time purchase, no ads	Paprika	Strong user goodwill; ads feel wrong in a health product

Opportunities for differentiation

The strongest position is "the meal planner that checks every recipe for pregnancy safety": mainstream planning quality, plus a safety layer no mainstream app has.

1. **Pregnancy safety check on every recipe and ingredient.** Tag each ingredient Recommended, Limit or Avoid, with the reason (Listeria, mercury, raw egg, caffeine) and the safe version ("use pasteurized feta", "cook salmon to 145°F"). Show a badge on recipe cards, like Samsung Food's Health Score.
2. **Check recipes users import.** Combine Paprika-style web import with the safety check, so a recipe from any blog is scanned and gets one-tap fixes. No competitor does this well today.
3. **Trimester-aware nutrition targets.** Replace calorie and macro goals with pregnancy-relevant nutrients (folate, iron, choline, iodine, calcium, DHA, protein) and show a weekly view of how the plan covers them. Eat This Much's "regenerate to hit targets" is the right interaction.
4. **Symptom modes.** Filters and plan presets for nausea, heartburn, constipation, aversions and low energy (fewer steps, cold meals, small portions), and later for gestational-diabetes-friendly carbs if reviewed by a clinician.
5. **Sourced, region-aware guidance.** Like Pregnant Food: Eat or Avoid, cite the authority behind each rule (FDA, CDC, ACOG in the US; NHS in the UK) and let users pick their country, since guidance differs. Have a registered dietitian review content and name them, as NYT Cooking names its experts.
6. **Safety inside the shopping list and pantry.** Flag unsafe items when added (unpasteurized juice, deli meat) and add leftover "use by" reminders.
7. **Quick "Can I eat this?" lookup** inside the same app, by search or barcode, so users don't need a second app.
8. **Partner sharing.** A shared plan and list so a partner can cook and shop, borrowed from Plan to Eat.
9. **Life-stage continuity.** Extend into postpartum and breastfeeding, then family meals, so the product isn't abandoned after birth. Mealime's shutdown shows a narrow product needs a longer customer lifetime.
10. **Trust-first business model.** Avoid ads and Walmart-style commerce in a health product. Options: a freemium subscription, a one-time unlock (Paprika-style), or a B2B channel through clinics and dietitians (like Eat This Much Pro).

Risks to plan for: safety rules must be accurate, sourced and kept current; the app should state it is not medical advice and point users to their clinician; and any AI chat answering food-safety questions should answer only from your vetted database.